

Chronicle of a Survival Foretold: How Protest Behavior Against Armed Actors Influenced Violence in the Colombian Civil War, 1988–2005

Carlos Enrique Moreno León

ABSTRACT

This article examines the circumstances under which civilians, using protests as a mechanism, alter the strategic use of violence by armed actors (rebels and state forces). By examining the civil war in Colombia between 1988 and 2005, this study finds that combatants decrease their attacks against the population when civilians protest against the enemy. Combatants interpret such demonstrations as costly signals of loyalty. Furthermore, when insurgents are the target of the protests, insurgents increase repression against civilians as rebels get stronger. In contrast, state forces (and paramilitaries) compensate for their weakness in the area by multiplying civilian victims. Both state forces and rebels, however, are likely to decrease violence against civilians when civilians protest against both parties in contested zones. In such contexts, armed actors are likely to refrain from retaliation because any violence might drive noncombatants toward the enemy.

January 27, 2005 was a terrible day for the town of San Miguel, Putumayo. A party of paramilitaries arrived in this municipality of southern Colombia and murdered six people. The following day, the shaken community was so appalled by this atrocity that it held a public demonstration against the paramilitaries. Unfortunately, the protest was not well received by the paramilitary group's leaders. Over the next few months, the armed group killed some of the protest organizers and threatened further violent reprisals. The warning was clear: protesting has a price (CINEP 2005).

Contrast this with the very different experience of the inhabitants of Nuquí, Cauca. On January 13, 2008, the Fuerzas Armadas Revolucionarias de Colombia (FARC) kidnapped six tourists. Although the travelers were not residents of Nuquí, the community mobilized peacefully against the insurgents to demand the release of the hostages. The people wanted the FARC to change its behavior; at stake was the reputation of the town for tourists and future visitors. The guerrillas, unlike the paramilitaries, did not punish or threaten the community for its organized opposition (CINEP 2008). Instead, the FARC freed four of the captives, just as the protestors had demanded (*El Tiempo* 2008).

Carlos Enrique Moreno León is an assistant professor in the Department of Political Studies, Universidad Icesi. cemoreno@icesi.edu.co

These examples illustrate two types of responses that armed actors make when civilians mobilize peacefully against them. Sometimes armed actors change their behavior, as the FARC did, and at other times, they punish the community for its hostile attitude, as the paramilitaries did. If these two options are possible, when are armed actors more prone to punishing the municipalities that protest? Why do combatants refrain from attacking civilians when they mobilize? Can demonstrations influence military organizations' attitudes toward civilians? The answers to these questions may be contingent on the context of the interaction between combatants and civilians. For this reason, this study attempts to identify the conditions under which protests against armed actors alter combatants' violent behavior.

This article argues that the reaction of armed actors toward demonstrations depends on both the target of those mobilizations and the level of control that armed actors exert over the territory.¹ In this sense, armed actors should have the opportunity and the will to punish protest behavior. When civilians mobilize against a single force, the wronged organization is likely to escalate its attacks on the community as it gets stronger. The aggrieved group then interprets those public demonstrations as challenges against its authority that come from enemy supporters. In contrast, armed actors are likely to reduce repression toward the community when noncombatants instead choose to mobilize against the enemy. Combatants then recognize that civilian protest is a costly signal of loyalty.

The second argument is that the predominant actor refrains from attacking the communities that mobilize against it only when the population's loyalty was known before the demonstration. When the strongest party and civilians share the same political identity, combatants are likely to recognize and tolerate the demonstrations, which they interpret as a sincere demand for changing violent behavior in the area.

In addition, this article posits that neutral protests (demonstrations against all warring parties) are likely to have only a negative effect on the levels of violence in contested zones. Any action against those communities might drive noncombatants to seek protection with the enemy.

The article proceeds to discuss the strategic interactions between civilians and armed actors in civil wars. Then it presents the different reactions of armed actors toward protest behavior, and a discussion of the research design and the results of the empirical analysis. The article concludes with interpretations and recommendations for future research.

BEHAVIOR OF ARMED ACTORS TOWARD CIVILIANS

In recent years, scholars who have highlighted the terrible consequences of civil wars on civilians (e.g., Fearon and Laitin 2003) have made an effort to understand the reasons that lead both rebels and state forces to use violence against noncombatants during civil conflicts. Some studies interpret the relationship among insurgents, state forces, and civilians from a strategic perspective in which the decision to punish the population is intended to maximize the utility function of armed actors by con-

sidering the possible reactions of both civilians and the enemy in the territory (Kalyvas 2006; Metelits 2010). So far, analysts have assumed that civilians are important assets for defeating the enemy because they provide indispensable resources (information, food, and manpower, among others) to carry on the war effort (Kalyvas 2006). As a consequence, earning and keeping the loyalty of the population becomes an essential goal for both parties in civil wars.

Lately, the governance of armed actors has aroused the interest of some scholars. They have emphasized that armed actors, in the absence of military competition, use alternative strategies to earn the allegiance of the population. That is, combatants pursue their military goals by developing a long-term strategy. They provide security, conflict resolution, and public goods in exchange for obedience and economic resources. Following this approach, armed actors might give up temporary (and maybe ephemeral) benefits, but in return, they have the opportunity to build their own constituency, secure funds in the long term, and minimize defections to the enemy (Wickham-Crowley 1987; Arjona 2010; Metelits 2010; Mampilly 2011).

Such gains are worth the wait. However, this strategy is suboptimal when combatants compete with other organizations for the loyalty of the population and the wealth in the area. In those situations, combatants shift their mentality as survival pushes them toward a short-term strategy, making long-term investments, such as provision of public goods, a luxury. Using violence then becomes the armed actors' best mechanism for achieving control over the pool of resources and supporters. Repression helps them to quickly amass large amounts of resources and cuts off funding siphoned toward the opposition. Using violence, intimidation, and other fear-inducing strategies, combatants punish those who support the enemy, sever their loyalty to the other side, and tilt the balance of power in their own favor (Ron 2001; Azam and Hoeffler 2002; Metelits 2010; Valentino 2014).

When armed actors choose to use violence, they can repress either indiscriminately or selectively. When they repress indiscriminately, they attempt to achieve two possible outcomes. First, they try to persuade civilians to support them by demonstrating the enemy's incapacity to provide security (Valentino et al. 2004; Downes 2006; Lyall 2009; Fjelding and Shortland 2012). Second, they seek to change the composition of the population by forcing the opponent's constituency to leave and later replacing it with their own supporters (Downes 2006; Costalli and Moro 2012; Steele 2011).

Unfortunately, using indiscriminate violence might backfire and induce civilians to seek protection from the opposite party (Mason 1996; Kalyvas 2006; Viterna 2006). Widespread abuses of civilians also create a bad reputation that, in the long run, might lead to the conscription of uncommitted followers, who might desert as soon as they have the opportunity (Eck 2014; Akcinaroglu and Tokdemir 2016).

For this reason, armed actors may limit coercive strategies and violence against civilians. For example, they may choose to target specific individuals who have acted against their commands and desires. Combatants then are more likely to punish civilians without alienating their supporters (Kalyvas 2006). In all cases, the descriptions of the armed actors' behavior presume that the agency of civilians is reactive. There are

only two variables, depending on the circumstances: noncombatants either choose to devote their allegiance to one of the parties in confrontation or move to other locations where they cannot be harmed on the basis of their political or ethnic identities.

Rational combatants therefore have to weigh the costs and benefits of violence and react to the behavior of civilians. In short, ignoring the wishes of civilians has consequences that may be harmful to achieving the combatants' long-term goals. When armed actors face civilians who are highly organized, they cannot carry out an order that disregards the people's preferences. Combatants must negotiate with the community unless they are willing to engage in constant conflict with civilians (Arjona 2010; Kaplan 2010; Metelits 2010; Mampilly 2011).

In Colombia, for example, both rebels and paramilitaries agree to channel their grievances against civilians who support a party to the confrontation through the Peasant Worker Association of the Carare River (ATCC), a civilian organization that declares its reluctance to support any party in the war. The community has a screening process to determine which inhabitants take a side in the confrontation and punish those civilians who violate the position of neutrality. In this case, armed actors accommodate local people's requirements, and so the levels of violence in the ATCC-affiliated municipalities are much lower than the punishment exerted by both rebels and paramilitaries in the neighboring non-ATCC towns (Kaplan 2013). In this situation, armed actors must respond to the challenges posed by civilians, not the other way around.

While armed actors alter their violent conduct for the intervention of autonomous civilian organizations such as the ATCC, combatants are also exposed to alternative repertoires that civilians use to criticize their behavior in the region. Armed actors occasionally face public opposition through protests (Stoll 1993; Shah 2008; Moreno León 2015). Their response to those demonstrations is mixed: while in some cases combatants address the people's grievances, in others, armed groups punish the municipalities that mobilize. When are armed actors more prone to punishing protesters? Why do combatants refrain from attacking the civilians that mobilize? Can demonstrations influence military organizations' actions toward civilians?

TO PUNISH OR NOT TO PUNISH

In irregular wars, armed actors generally require civilian support to fight their enemy effectively. They depend on resources that noncombatants provide, such as information, food, shelter, and manpower (Kalyvas 2006). Since the population's loyalty is so important to defeating the enemy, armed actors may use violence as a mechanism to punish civilians who collaborate with the opposition. However, it is hard to distinguish where noncombatants place their allegiance because the territorial boundaries are blurred in war. Actually, supporters and members of both parties can mimic each other in order to avoid detection. Therefore, both rebels and state forces face the same identification problem wherever they operate: they are unsure who their supporters are (Kalyvas 2006).

Indiscriminate violence is one option open to combatants. That is, rather than target only collaborators with the enemy, armed groups could punish the entire population (Valentino et al. 2004; Downes 2006; Lyall 2009). In many cases, this strategy backfires, driving the communities to seek the adversary's protection (Mason 1996; Kalyvas 2006; Viterina 2006). For this reason, military organizations benefit more from occasionally, selectively punishing civilians (Kalyvas 2006). One of the mechanisms they use to overcome the information asymmetry is to rely on informants who live with noncombatants. However, not all informants are trustworthy: snitches might use the combatants' trust in their information for their own benefit (e.g., about vendettas, marital affairs, and land issues) (Kalyvas and Kocher 2007).

Armed groups can also use civilians' political and ethnic affiliations to identify potential collaborators and determine if the community has civilian enemy supporters; this is known as collective targeting (Balcells 2010; Steele 2011; Costalli and Moro 2012; Fjelde and Hultman 2013). However, living in places where most people belong to a certain ethnic group or are affiliated with a specific political party is not an indication that all civilians support any particular force. Armed actors who use such mechanisms to punish civilians do so not because of verified guilt but rather, guilt by association. Ultimately, all the screening mechanisms that both rebels and state forces use to overcome the identification problem are flawed.

Given these informational problems, combatants face mobilizations against one or both parties in the confrontation. However, the attitudes of armed actors toward those demonstrations depend heavily on the targets of those protests. For example, on February 4, 2008, a group of civilians organized national and international demonstrations against the FARC. Thousands of people joined the protest all across Colombia and in many other countries around the world. While the FARC condemned those who mobilized as instruments of the Colombian government, intended to manipulate public opinion in favor of re-electing President Álvaro Uribe Vélez for a third term, the government thanked the demonstrators for showing their opposition to the rebels and renewed its promise to help bring peace to Colombia (abpnoticias.com 2008; Uribe Vélez 2008).

When the population's loyalties are unknown, armed actors are likely to use demonstrations as costly signals of loyalty, since civilians undertake them despite the likely negative consequences of violent retaliation. Noncombatants take the risk to show publicly their disagreement with one of the warring parties, knowing full well that the aggrieved group might punish or kill them for such conduct. Protests then push combatants to decide whether to punish the protestors or not, and they shape the willingness of both rebels and state forces to repress the population.

When armed actors face public demonstrations against the enemy, combatants are reluctant to exert any kind of violence on the community, since civilians have proven their loyalty by showing their dissatisfaction with the opposite side. Otherwise, armed actors might damage their base of support and undermine their own position. In contrast, combatants are eager to punish communities that protest against them, generally interpreting the demonstrations as acts of defiance and exhibiting only minimal tolerance (Tilly 2003). When armed actors realize that

civilians are defecting to the other side, they can selectively punish the protestors without driving the rest of the population to the other party's protection.

Now, willingness is not the only factor to consider in understanding the armed actors' response. Combatants also have to evaluate their opportunity to carry out violent actions. The capacity to punish defectors depends greatly on territorial control. Having the monopoly on violence allows the dominant group to enforce a set of stable institutions that facilitate the extraction of economic resources, the protection of genuine supporters, the punishment of defectors, and effective monitoring of the population. The powerful actor can then credibly deter any opposition against its control, since it can, in fact, immediately sanction any challenger or enemy supporter (Kalyvas 2006). Territorial control, after all, brings the capacity to control and establish effective sovereignty over the residents. Thus, combatants who are the predominant force in the territory will have the willingness; the opportunity, manifested in terms of manpower; and the resources to punish the communities who oppose them, and the weaker party, to whom the protestors show their allegiance, will not be able to challenge the dominant actor's punishment.

The aggrieved actor's response, however, is likely to be very different when it is the weaker party in the area. Despite its willingness to punish communities that dare to take a stand against it, the armed group will lack the capacity to do so. The lack of control over the territory prevents any attempt to repress the population in the area, because weak actors have to overcome both the scarcity of economic resources and manpower and the protection that the powerful group provides to the community (Mason 1996; Kalyvas 2006; Asal and Rethemeyer 2008).

In contrast, armed actors should react differently when civilians protest against the enemy. In those circumstances, the willingness to punish will be absent. Combatants will treat protests against the enemy as informative signals of the citizens' loyalty and will be expected to offer their protection (see table 1).

So far, this analysis has assumed that the population's loyalties are unknown, so any action challenging the powerful actor's authority is likely to be punished. The story is different, however, when the local noncombatants share the powerful actor's political ideology.² In such cases, combatants enjoy the capability to punish those civilians who challenge their authority, but they refrain from castigating the mobilized community. That is, this study argues, the willingness to punish does not exist.

When armed actors choose an ideology, they make a normative commitment to defend the interests of a specific constituency (Gutiérrez Sanín and Wood 2014). Armed actors then pursue a set of strategies that allow them to build a positive reputation among their followers (e.g., distribution of public goods, provision of security, and implementing a well-thought-out communication strategy, among others), and refrain from actions that might sever that bond (Akcinaroglu and Tokdemir 2016). By doing so, they guarantee a stream of committed recruits and material resources from the community that believes in their cause. Despite sharing the same ideology, however, the preferences of armed actors and their supporters toward the methods used by combatants to achieve the goals of the struggle (e.g., excessive use of force, targets of violence) may sometimes diverge. The constituency of the dom-

Table 1. Levels of Violence According to Willingness and Capacity to Punish

		Capacity to Punish	
		Weak	Strong
Willingness to	Protest against armed actor (yes)	Low levels of violence inflicted	High levels of violence inflicted
Punish	Protest against enemy (no)	Low levels of violence inflicted	Low levels of violence inflicted

inant group might then try to alter or modify the behavior of armed actors in a desired direction (Heger 2015). Protesting then prepares the stage for these negotiations that are set to take place between the armed actor and its loyal constituency.

In such a situation, the powerful actor possesses the capacity to punish the mobilizing communities, but by doing so, it is likely to tarnish its reputation and alienate its civilian base (Angstrom 2001; Wood 2014). By accommodating its supporters' demands, however, it can improve its bonds with the community and reap the benefits of building a positive reputation. In this sense, despite having the opportunity to harm those who mobilize, it is optimal for military organizations to refrain from inflicting violence when they are assured of the sincerity of their supporters.³ This leads to the following hypothesis:

- H1. An increase in protests against the state forces and paramilitaries (rebels)*
- a. decreases rebel (state forces and paramilitary) violence,*
 - b. increases violence by state forces and paramilitaries (rebels) when the state forces and paramilitaries (rebels) are strong,*
 - c. decreases violence by state forces and paramilitaries (rebels) when the state forces and paramilitaries (rebels) are strong and protestors are prostate (prorebel).*

So far, this review has covered the reaction of combatants to demonstrations directed toward one organization. However, on other occasions, civilians refrain from picking a side and demand a change in the behavior of both warring parties. For example, on June 4, 1995, banana worker unions of Uraba, Colombia, demonstrated against both insurgents and paramilitaries. In this context, civilians complained about the abuses of both armed actors. The continuous struggle to achieve territorial control was disturbing the daily life of the inhabitants of Uraba to the extent that the violence was sabotaging the banana economy of the area, the principal source of income for the families of the region (Pérez 1995).

What happens in cases in which civilians target both actors? Again, the level of control that armed actors exert over the territory can explain their actions. When civilians engage in neutral protests in places where one actor is stronger than the other, they provide little information about the allegiances of the population. Given the flawed screening mechanisms in overcoming the information asymmetry problem, it is likely that actors, depending on their capabilities, will interpret those actions

as challenges to their control and will be inclined to harm communities that are reluctant to pick a side in the confrontation (Kalyvas 2006; Uribe de Hincapié 2009).

The story is a little different when neutral protests occur in contested zones. Mobilizing against both parties is not helpful in distinguishing the supporters of each side. However, the alternative mechanisms available for determining the population's loyalties are equally unreliable. Armed actors do not have the capabilities to detect and punish civilians without alienating the population (Kalyvas 2006). Therefore, punishing them might bring more problems than solutions. One possible civilian reaction would be to organize further mobilizations. When civilians belong to well-endowed, well-disciplined organizations, they can escalate the conflict. Without engaging in violence or supporting any party in the war, noncombatants could increase the polarization in the territory, signaling their commitment to their cause until armed actors accommodate their demands (Kaplan 2010). Any violence by armed actors in this context can push civilians to the enemy side. In this case, violence may generate defections and a shift in the balance of power in favor of the rival (Kalyvas 2006). Neutral demonstrations in contested zones, therefore, decrease the will to punish and force both parties at war to refrain from taking action against the population, since the alternatives may prove to be more costly. Therefore,

H2. Neutral protests are more likely to decrease violent attacks against civilians by both warring parties in contested zones.

COLOMBIA AS A STUDY CASE

The persistence of the Colombian civil conflict has driven armed actors to achieve a certain level of experience in handling civilians. Combatants have experienced situations in which civilians have organized to fight against insurgents, but also occasions when civilians have organized to resist the presence of armed actors. With respect to the latter, armed actors have bargained with autonomous organizations with the aim of restricting their relationship with the population (Hernández Delgado 2004; Hancock and Mitchell 2007; Bouvier 2009; Mitchell and Hancock 2012; Masullo 2015). However, armed actors also have faced public demonstrations against their presence to shape their preferences toward violence. According to the Social Struggles Dataset from the Center for Research and Popular Education (CINEP), 14 percent of all demonstrations in Colombia between 1975 and 2010 were protests against one or more armed actors in the war. Protesting against armed actors is commonplace in Colombia.

This study attempts to assess how civilians transform the local dynamics of war. It compares how the political and military characteristics of municipalities influence armed actors' use of violence during civil wars. To do so, the unit of analysis is the municipality-month. Unfortunately, there is not much cross-national information about the local dynamics of civil war and protest behavior. However, in Colombia, considerable information has been collected about the dynamics of the civil war and

related protest behavior at the local level (Restrepo and Spagat 2006). Therefore, this country presents a good case for assessing the effects of demonstrations against one or both opposing parties on the violent behavior of armed actors in civil conflicts.

RESEARCH DESIGN AND DISCUSSION

The first focus is the reactions of the aggrieved armed actor. Two dependent variables are used to test the first part of the first hypothesis: the number of civilians killed by insurgents and the number of civilians murdered by state forces and paramilitaries. The source of the information is the Conflict Analysis Resource Center (CERAC) (Restrepo and Spagat 2006).

Three independent variables are used to test the first part of the first hypothesis: *the number of protests against the armed group*.⁴ The information is taken from the CINEP dataset of social struggles.⁵ This dataset uses national and regional newspapers, interviews with social movement leaders, and reports from social organizations to collect information about protests, which it defines as any public demonstration with at least ten participants.⁶ Second, *the relative power of insurgents* measures the capacity of rebel organizations to maintain a stable zone of control despite the enemy's effort. In this case, the belligerent processes are examined in areas beyond the legal limits of the towns, including neighboring territories (Kalyvas 2006).

Under these terms, armed actors who control an extensive territory are less likely to be exposed to frequent shifts in power. Both armed actors and civilians can, therefore, form stable expectations about their future strategic interactions. This variable is created by dividing the number of casualties among state forces and paramilitaries during the previous 12 months by the number of casualties among all forces in the conflict during the previous 12 months within a radius of 25 km (15.53 miles) around the municipality.⁷ It is assumed that civilians evaluate the strength of armed actors by reviewing the interactions during the previous year among the parties at war. When the value of this variable is near 1, the balance of power favors the insurgents. However, when this value is near zero, the balance of power favors the state and paramilitaries.⁸ Finally, an interaction variable is created to evaluate how the variation in the number of protests against the military organization and the capability of insurgents influences the probability of incurring an additional fatality by the armed actor. The following control variables are used.

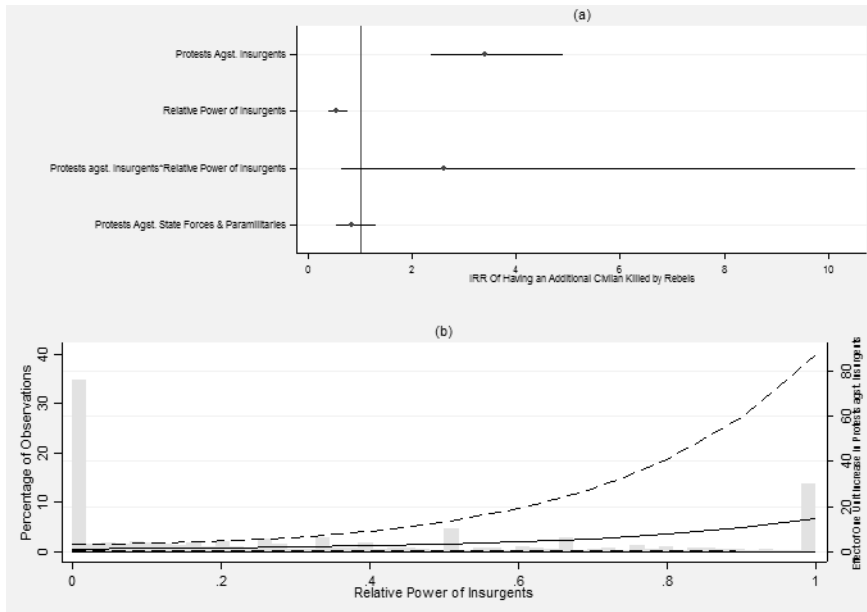
1. *Population density* uses population projection data from the National Administrative Department of Statistics (DANE) and geographic area data from the Agustín Codazzi Geographical Institute. Because of the variance of this variable, it is logged. Population density is used to assess how the concentration of people shapes the probability of being killed by armed actors.
2. DANE's *projection of the town's population* is also logged. Population is used to address how the number of inhabitants in the territory has an impact on the probability of incurring a victim in the civil war.

3. The *Unsatisfied Basic Needs Index* of the Colombian Census of 2005, prepared by DANE, is employed to account for the effect of poverty on the dynamics of the civil war.
4. The *altitude of the urban centers of the municipalities*, taken from the Agustín Codazzi Geographical Institute. This variable is used to evaluate how location in the mountains affects the use of violence by armed actors.
5. The *distance from the urban centers of each municipality to the closest regional capital*. These data are calculated with the geographic coordinates of each municipality of Colombia. They are used to assess how the proximity to state political centers shapes the repression of combatants.
6. A dummy variable to weight the *places in which military groups were organized* during *La Violencia*. The variable has a value of 1 if the municipality suffered violence during *La Violencia* and 0 otherwise (Daly 2012). This variable is used to assess how the impact of the organizational legacies of war influences current patterns of violence and rebellion (Daly 2012).
7. The presence of *oil exploitation* in the municipality. The variable has a value of 1 if oil production is taking place and 0 otherwise (Daly 2012).
8. A dummy variable to evaluate the *presence of gemstone mining*. The variable has a value of 1 if gems are present and 0 otherwise (Daly 2012).
9. Another dummy variable to assess the *presence of coca-growing operations* in the town, valued at 1 if coca crops are produced and 0 otherwise (Daly 2012). These three variables—oil, gems, and coca—are used to take account of how looting of illegal and legal commodities catalyzes the violent behavior of armed actors.
10. The *number of kilometers of roads* in the municipality (Daly 2012). Because of the variance of this variable, it is logged. It helps to evaluate how access to the municipality influences the use of violence by all armed actors.
11. The *number of months without violent actions* by the armed actor.
12. The *square of the number of months* without violent actions by the armed actor.
13. The *cube of the number of months* without violent actions by the armed actor.

The last three variables attempt to address how previous patterns of violence influence the current dynamics of repression (Box-Steffensmeier and Jones 2004). The same control variables are used in all the models estimated in the study.⁹

Using a zero-inflated negative binomial, the analysis found that the armed actors' reaction depends on both the target of the protest and the level of control the actors exert over the territory.¹⁰ In the case of insurgents, protests against them incite further attacks against civilians once the rebels become the dominant force in the area (see figure 1).¹¹ However, the reaction of state forces and paramilitaries toward protests against them shows an unexpected finding. Mobilizing against paramilitaries and state forces increases violent actions from the incumbent when the relative power of insurgents escalates; that is, in zones where the incumbent is weaker (see figure 2).

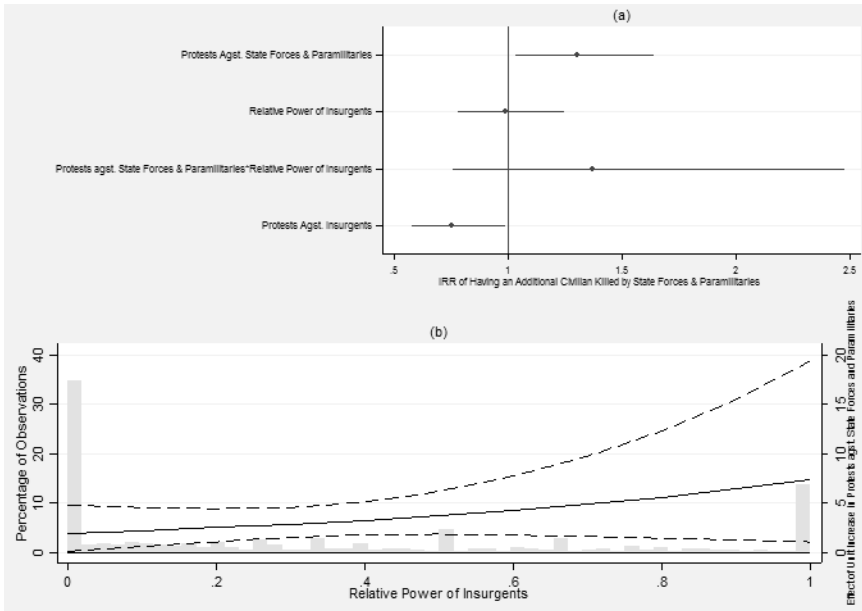
Figure 1. Zero-Inflated Models of the Effect of Protests on the Levels of Violence from Insurgents



I argue that when the aggrieved group is weak, the organization is unlikely to carry out any violent attacks because it lacks the resources and the manpower to pursue such a strategy, and more important, the dominant actor will do everything it can to protect its followers. However, this disregards the fact that the Colombian civil war is an asymmetrical confrontation. No matter the level of control that rebels have over the territory, the incumbent always has more resources to expend, and as a consequence, it can overcome the possible protection that insurgents provide to their constituencies (e.g., aerial bombardment). In contrast, the incumbent can guarantee the safety of the protestors targeting the guerrilla forces because it can deter more effectively any indiscriminate action against the population.

Therefore, the behavior of state forces and paramilitaries might respond to their lack of strength in the area by increasing the number of civilian victims. In many cases, the army has used indiscriminate violence to deter civilians from supporting insurgents or, in the worst-case scenario, to cleanse the area of the rebels' supporters (Downes 2006; Kalyvas 2006; Kalyvas and Kocher 2009; Fjelding and Shortland 2012). In this particular case, state forces and paramilitaries might take this chance to prove the guerrillas incapable of properly defending the community by increasing their violent actions against the mobilizing communities.

Figure 2. Zero-Inflated Models of the Effect of Protests on the Levels of Violence from State Forces and Paramilitaries



Armed Actors' Reactions to Protests Against the Enemy

The second part of the first hypothesis is tested using the same dependent variables as the previous section. In this case, the *number of protests against the enemy* is used as the independent variable. When the model evaluates insurgent violence, the number of protests against paramilitaries and state forces is used; in contrast, when the model evaluates the violence from paramilitaries and state forces, the number of protests against insurgents is used.

In this case, the analysis found that protesting against the enemy has a negative effect on the levels of violence inflicted by armed actors. For every additional protest against insurgents, the predicted mean of the number of civilians killed by paramilitaries and state forces decreases by 29.4 percent, holding other variables constant (see figure 2). In contrast, protesting against state forces and paramilitaries has a negative impact on the repressive behavior of insurgents. However, this variable is not significant (see figure 1).

Reactions of the Aggrieved Armed Actor in Zones of Dominance

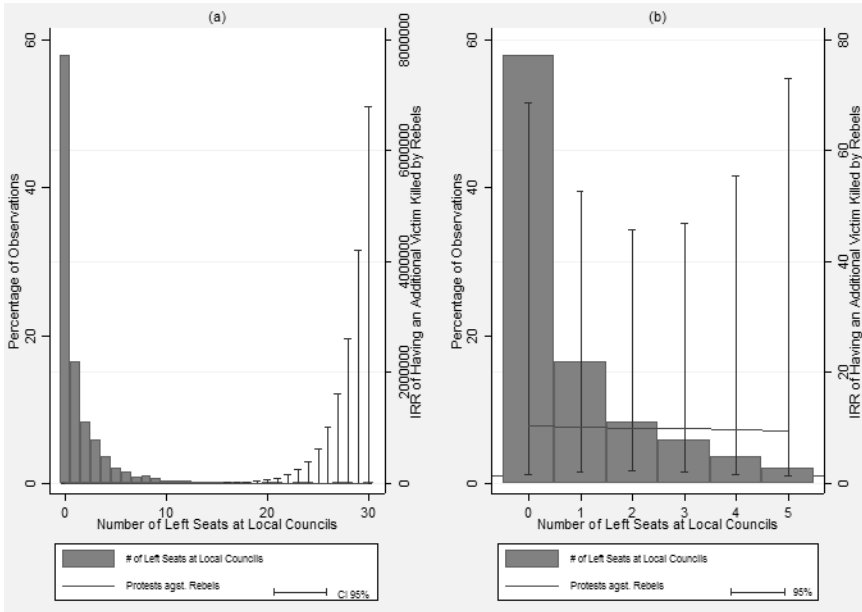
Testing the last part of the first hypothesis again uses the same dependent variables. The analysis employs three independent variables. The model that estimates violence from insurgents uses the *number of protests against insurgents*. Second, the variable *presence of leftist parties* is constructed by aggregating the number of seats that leftist parties have on the local council within a radius of 25 km (15.53 miles) around the municipality.¹² This information is coded from the electoral statistics of the National Civil Registry. This analysis addresses the extent to which the preferences of noncombatants are aligned with the rebels in the area. In addition, an interaction variable is created to evaluate how the variation in the number of protests against rebels and the people's loyalty toward insurgents influences the probability of additional insurgent killings in the town.

In contrast, the model that estimates violence from state forces and paramilitaries uses the *number of protests against state forces and paramilitaries*. Second, the variable *presence of non-leftist parties* is created by aggregating the number of seats that non-leftist parties have on the local council within a radius of 25 km (15.53 miles) around the municipality. This information is coded from the electoral statistics of the National Civil Registry as well. An interaction variable also is created to evaluate how the variation in the number of protests against state forces and paramilitaries and the people's loyalty toward the incumbent influences the probability that state forces and paramilitaries will cause additional fatalities in the town.

Since I am particularly interested in the conduct of dominant actors in the third part of the first hypothesis, I take a subset of the sample to make my empirical analysis. I use only a subsample for testing H1c.¹³ The model that evaluates violence by insurgents uses only the observations in which the value of relative power of insurgents is higher than .667, because in such zones, insurgents are expected to punish protests against them, while in the others they are not. Meanwhile, I employ only the observations where the value of the relative power of insurgents is lower than .333 for the model that estimates the violence from state forces and paramilitaries. Again, in such zones, the incumbent is likely to behave differently than in the other zones.

The last part of the first hypothesis proposes that the political identity of communities plays an important role in the manner that armed actors respond to mobilizations. I argue that powerful military organizations will be reluctant to punish civilians who have previously made public declarations of loyalty to them (e.g., voting behavior). When rebels are strong and civilians share the same ideology, rebels decrease their violent actions against communities that mobilize against them. However, the negative impact on the insurgents' levels of violence is insignificant beyond five seats occupied by leftist parties (see figure 3). This outcome should be interpreted while keeping in mind that 89 percent of the observations of the sample are between zero and five leftist seats on the local councils. Therefore, while the expectations of the levels of violence by insurgents are confirmed for the majority of the cases in the data, in other instances, when state forces and paramilitaries are the

Figure 3. Incidence Rate Ratio of an Additional Fatality by Rebels



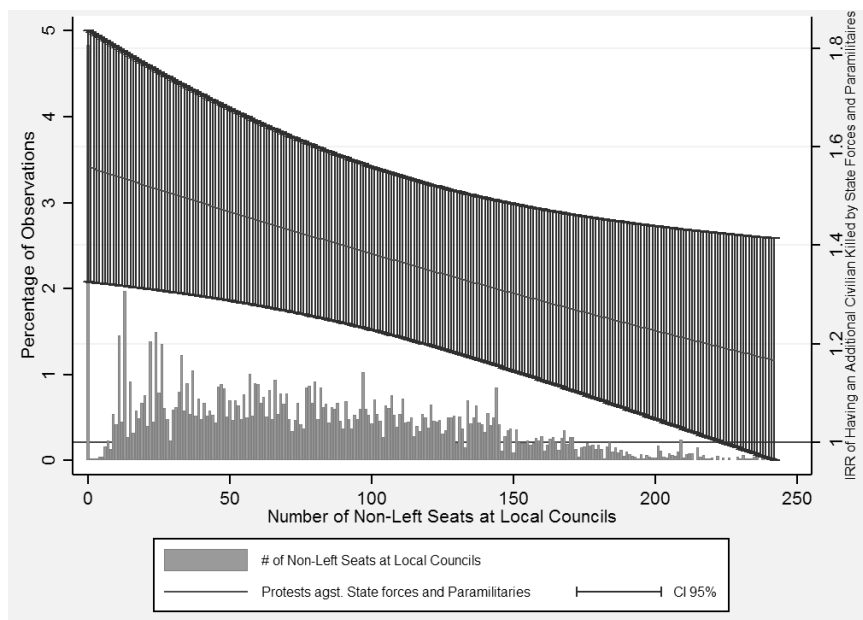
dominant force and the presence of leftist parties decreases, state forces and paramilitaries reduce their violent actions against the noncombatants who mobilize against them (see figure 4). In this case, state forces and paramilitaries recognize the need to change their behavior in order to keep the population's loyalty.

**Armed Actors' Reactions
to Neutral Protests**

For the second hypothesis, the analysis employs as the dependent variable the number of civilians assassinated by all the forces in conflict. The source of the information is CERAC (Restrepo and Spagat 2006). Furthermore, it again uses three independent variables:

1. The *number of protests against both parties in the war*.
2. A dummy variable named *contested zones*. This variable has a value of 1 when the relative power of insurgents is higher than .333 and lower than .667, and 0 otherwise.
3. An interaction variable to assess what impact the variation in the number of protests against all groups in confrontation and the relative power of insurgents has on the levels of violence by all warring parties.

Figure 4. Incidence Rate Ratio of an Additional Fatality by Paramilitaries and State Forces

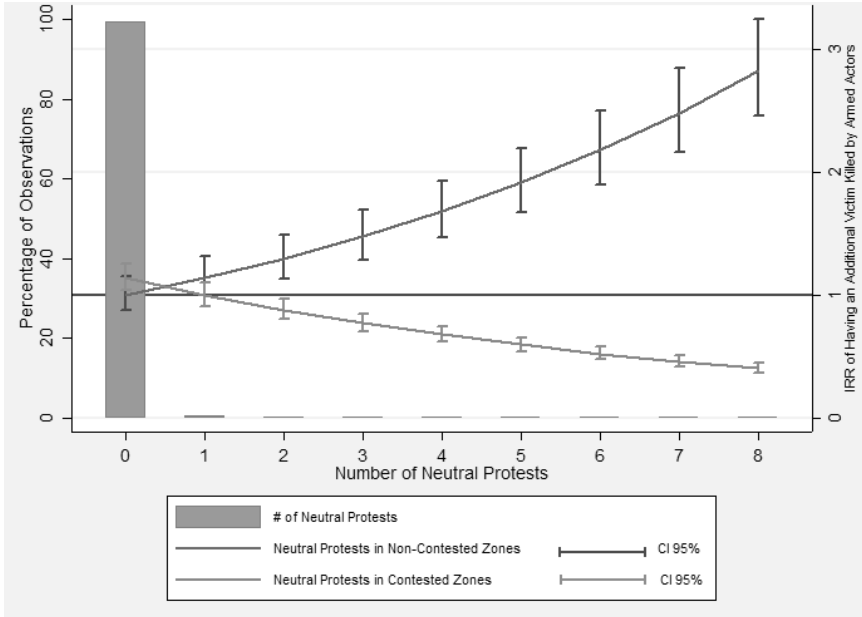


As expected, the analysis finds support for the last hypothesis. Neutral protests increase the levels of violence only in places where there is a dominant force in the territory (see figure 5). In contrast, the levels of violence decline when there is an incremental increase in the number of demonstrations against both parties in contested zones. However, one protest is not likely to make a difference. Indeed, it is not possible to distinguish the effect of neutral protests in contested zones from those in uncontested areas. The difference in behavior is apparent only when civilians mobilize more than once a month. Especially where citizens mobilize frequently (more than twice a month), the decrease in violence in contested zones becomes significant. Therefore, only persistent and frequent neutral mobilizations that reveal civilian commitment induce a change in the patterns of violence in the community. Otherwise, neutral mobilizations may fail to be effective.

ROBUSTNESS CHECK

Besides the variables used in all the models, the violent dynamics in civil war might also respond to other factors. Along with the local characteristics of municipalities, the violent behavior of armed actors might echo the regional strategy of combatants. On the other hand, the civilian capacity to engage in negotiations with armed actors might also influence the affinity that combatants have with the communities.

Figure 5. Incidence Rate Ratio of an Additional Fatality by All Armed Actors



However, such a possibility is available only for those noncombatants who are able to solve their collective action problem and agree to act together. For that reason, this study estimates all the models with two additional control variables: the spatial lag of the dependent variable of the respective model, and the number of protests unrelated to the civil conflict. These variables are used as an indicator of the institutional and organizational strength of civilians. As the online appendix shows, similar results were obtained by introducing both control variables. Protesting against insurgents boosts rebel attacks against noncombatants as insurgents get stronger (see appendix table 6 and figure 1). On the other hand, mobilizing against state forces and paramilitaries has a negative and insignificant effect on the level of rebel violence. Meanwhile, protesting against state forces and paramilitaries increases the number of civilians killed by state forces and paramilitaries as insurgents get stronger. Moreover, for every additional protest against insurgents, the expected mean number of civilians killed by state forces and paramilitaries decreases by 23 percent, holding other variables constant.

Now, mobilizing against the strong actor decreases the levels of violence against civilians if they share similar ideological views. When rebels are strong and civilians share the same ideology, rebels diminish their violent actions against communities that mobilize against them. In contrast, when state forces and paramilitaries are the dominant force and the presence of leftist parties decreases, state forces and paramilitaries reduce their violent actions against the noncombatants who mobilize against them.

On the other hand, protesting against all warring parties in contested zones decreases the number of civilian casualties. However, one protest is not going to make a difference. Civilians must mobilize at least twice per month in order to shape the preferences of armed actors toward violence.

So far, this analysis has assumed that paramilitaries and state forces act together, as some studies and reports have shown. However, in other circumstances, paramilitaries differentiate themselves from state forces because they loot from their bureaucratic organizations. For this reason, the analysis estimates a new set of models that evaluate independently the use of violence by paramilitaries and state forces. As the online appendix shows, protesting against paramilitaries and state forces increases the number of civilians killed by paramilitaries. However, such an effect becomes negative as soon as the insurgent dominance increases. In contrast, protesting against paramilitaries and state forces increases the levels of violence of state forces toward civilians. Furthermore, such an impact is more pronounced as insurgents get stronger.

While the first hypothesis is supported in the case of paramilitaries, the behavior of state forces deviates from expectations. However, this analysis confirms that state forces can easily overcome the protection that rebels might provide to civilians and collectively target those municipalities that are willing to mobilize against the state forces and paramilitaries, challenging the rebels' capacity to offer protection to those communities they claim to represent. In many cases, the army has used indiscriminate violence to deter civilians from supporting insurgents or, in the worst-case scenario, to cleanse the area of rebel supporters (Downes 2006; Kalyvas 2006; Kalyvas and Kocher 2009; Fjelding and Shortland 2012).

I additionally include in the empirical section analyses that evaluate independently the levels of violence of paramilitaries and state forces and the number of *protests against insurgents*, with the aim of testing the second part of my first hypothesis. In both statistical models, protesting against rebels has a negative and insignificant effect on the level of violence by paramilitaries and state forces. Although both tests are incapable of rejecting the null hypothesis, this study presents some evidence that mobilizing against insurgents might jointly modify the behavior of paramilitaries and state forces.

A final couple of models are run to observe independently the behavior of paramilitaries and state forces in their areas of dominance. In the case of the model that evaluates the behavior of paramilitaries, the estimates show that protesting against state forces and paramilitaries increases the probability of having an additional fatality by paramilitaries. However, such a probability decreases as the number of non-leftist parties in the region increases. That is, paramilitaries recognize the need to change their behavior in order to keep the population's loyalty. In contrast, the model that evaluates the behavior of state forces shows that in the areas controlled by the government, the number of fatalities increases as the number of non-leftist parties at local councils grows. However, such a tendency is significant only when the number of non-leftist seats on local councils is higher than 58. The strength of the state in the areas of its dominance might explain this outcome. State forces have

greater resources and capacity than any other irregular group in the war. Therefore, state forces could demand from civilians an absolute, unquestioning loyalty. If civilians show opposition, state forces will punish those who dare to mobilize, since the state can hardly lose control over the areas it already dominates.

CONCLUSIONS

The use of violence during civil wars has been interpreted, in many cases, from a strategic perspective. According to this point of view, the repression exerted by armed actors shapes the preferences of civilians. Despite the power inequality, both insurgents and state forces change their behavior in response to civilian strategies. On different occasions, armed actors bargain with civilians organized around autonomous organizations to determine the extent of their permissible intervention in the community. Combatants must also deal with other resistance repertoires used by civilians, such as protests. As this article has described it, the effect of civilian demonstrations against armed actors on the levels of actors' violence is conditional on the combatants' capability and willingness to consider civilians' demands.

This article has argued that when armed actors are the dominant force in the area, they tend to punish the communities that defy their authority. Demonstrations are costly signals that reveal the actors to whom civilians devote their loyalty. The powerful group tends not to tolerate mobilizations against its presence because it interprets those actions as evidence of support for the enemy. Therefore, we could expect that it will punish any communities that defy it in this way. However, the empirical analysis here shows that only insurgents behave in this way.

State forces and paramilitaries increase the repression against noncombatants when they get weaker and face protests against their presence. Compared to insurgents, the incumbent always has more resources to expend, and as a consequence, it can overcome the possible protection that insurgents provide to their constituencies (e.g., aerial bombardment). Therefore, the behavior of state forces and paramilitaries might respond to their lack of strength in the area, as they try to compensate for their weakness by multiplying civilian victims.

On the other hand, armed actors should have a different reaction when the mobilizations are directed toward their enemies. They notice and reward the behavior of civilians who are taking the risk of going out and showing their disloyalty to the enemy, knowing full well that they risk retaliation. Hence, combatants abstain from violence against the protesting civilians. However, the empirical analysis only provides evidence that state forces and paramilitaries do, in fact, decrease their attacks against the population.

The story might be different, however, if we take into account the political beliefs of the population. If armed actors know beforehand the political inclinations of the community, public demonstrations by their constituencies need not be interpreted as actions of disloyalty but will be seen as genuine complaints about the behavior of armed actors in the community. The empirical analysis shows that insurgents, state forces, and paramilitaries reduce their violent actions in places they

control when people who have strong political allegiances to the dominant force mobilize against them.

Finally, neutral protests have a positive effect on the levels of violence from all parties in confrontation in noncontested zones. In contrast, neutral protests are able to reduce violence from all parties at war in contested zones. However, those mobilizations are only effective to the extent that they are not isolated events. Civilians need to undertake consistent protest behavior to produce a significant change in armed actors' violent practices.

Further research should compare different civil wars to understand civilian agency. Contrasting protest behavior in different conflictual contexts might be an effective way to test the conclusions of this study. For example, other studies could delve into ways that protest behavior against both state forces and rebels transforms the violent behavior of armed actors in ethnic wars, because the response of armed actors to mobilizations probably depends on the ethnic composition of the territory. Some protests not only would be tolerated but could also change the military organizations' attitude toward the community. However, some demonstrations might be repressed for challenging the authority of the dominant force.

On the other hand, the theoretical starting point of this study is that armed actors behave as unitary actors. Such an assumption disregards the tensions and differences that occur within any organization. Indeed, the variation in the behavior of armed actors might also depend on the characteristics of their field commanders (ICRC 2016). The response to civilian mobilization might be mediated by the leader who deals with the discontent of the population. For that reason, it would be worth gathering information in the future and analyzing how the character of field commandants influences the use of violence toward civilians in resistance.

NOTES

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1. Most rebels are weaker in civil conflicts. However, this study assumes that a powerful (or dominant) actor has the capacity to exert territorial control at the local level. Such capacity ensures exclusive relationships with civilians regardless of its enemy's strength.

2. Steele (2011) shows that the resilience of political ideology forces armed actors to perform strategic displacement. They recognize that conversion is impossible in some cases. Therefore, civilians do not always shape their preferences according to the dominant group, as Kalyvas (2006) claims.

3. So far, this argument has assumed that civilians are sincere. However, what if the supporters are not sincere, but are strategic instead? That is, the relative power in the territory may induce strategic behavior without necessarily changing the preferences of the civilians. Can armed actors be assured that ideological affinity toward the group indicates loyalty? It is very possible that noncombatants may cast their vote for, or pretend to embrace, the ideology of the new dominant organization as a mechanism for avoiding punishment. Therefore, in reality, the powerful group may be incapable of differentiating between its sincere and strate-

gic followers. However, because any action against the community might end up hurting genuine supporters and affecting its reputation in the territory, violence remains as a suboptimal outcome. When the protestors are the people who previously declared allegiance to the predominant force in the area, armed actors will have no option but to cease their violence against the population.

4. When the model evaluates insurgent violence, I use the number of protests against insurgents. In contrast, I use the number of protests against paramilitaries and state forces when the model evaluates the violence from paramilitaries and state forces. A distribution in time and space of the protests can be found in the online appendix.

5. From here on, all the information used in this article about protest behavior against armed actors comes from the same database.

6. According to the codebook, the dataset includes all political struggles from different sectors of the society (e.g., peasants, indigenous people, students, women, conflict victims, workers). All coded protests are collective actions that intentionally make demands to the government, private organizations, and, in this case, armed actors in order to correct injustices, inequalities, and exclusion in the society. Therefore, protests that are part of this study do not include rallies in favor of specific political forces.

7. An extensive description of the construction of this variable can be found in the appendix.

8. Information from the Human Rights and Humanitarian International Law Observatory.

9. All the models defined in the research design are estimated with all these control variables. At the suggestion of one of the reviewers, all those models are estimated with fewer control variables in order to simplify the statistical assessment. For each model and control variable, a set of Wald tests is conducted to determine which control variables should be dropped. The outcome of those models does not change the main findings of this study and does not necessarily improve the estimation process. Those models can be found in the appendix.

10. Zero-inflated negative binomial models are used in all the models estimated in this study to evaluate the effect of the main independent variables on armed actors' levels of violence. All the dependent variables have many zeros. There is a chance that the creation of zeros responds to two different processes: there might be municipalities in which armed actors never carry out violent actions and towns where armed actors have the opportunity to punish noncombatants but refrain from doing so. The zero-inflated model helps to adjust the estimates of the count equation according to the probability of finding zeros in the sample (Long 1997; Clark 2003). In the inflated equation, I use only the control variables. Additionally, I clustered the standard errors by municipality in all the models.

11. The estimates of all the models defined in the research design can be found in the appendix.

12. The leftist parties included are Alianza Nacional Popular, Vía Alterna, Movimiento Frente Esperanza, Frente Social y Político, Movimiento Obrero Independiente Revolucionario, Unidad Democrática, Movimiento Ciudadano, Autoridades Indígenas de Colombia, Opción Siete, Partido Comunista de Colombia, Partido Social Democrático, Corriente de Renovación Socialista, Educación, Trabajo y Cambio Social, Polo Democrático Independiente, Alianza Democrática M-19, Partido de los Trabajadores de Colombia, Unión Patriótica, and Partido Socialista de los Trabajadores y Frente Democrático.

13. The last part of my first hypothesis implies a three-way interaction. I am evaluating how the relationship between the number of protests and the levels of violence is contingent

not only on the relative power of insurgents but also on the ideological and electoral preferences of the population. Both the complexity of such evaluation and my interest in assessing the behavior of powerful actors lead me to take a subgroup of the sample, in this case observations in which armed actors are powerful, and test the effect of the number of protests on the levels of violence according to the change in the political preferences of the population. In such a situation, the relative power of insurgents is assumed as a constant in the subsample that minimizes its effect over the other variables (Aiken et al. 1991).

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SUPPORTING INFORMATION

Additional supporting materials may be found with the online version of this article at the publisher's website: Appendix.